

CHRISTINE FERNIE EDIT

Travel Radio Australia and as we're rolling into June in Australia, it's the start of our ski season. All around Australia and indeed around the world, we have opposite ski seasons and this is especially the case for Canada. And on the line, I have Christine Grimbale from Tourism Fernie.

And Christine, welcome to the program. Well, a pleasure to be joining you. Now, Christine, you are currently in Australia for the start of our ski season, which is in June, and it's just coming into your summer over there at Fernie in British Columbia.

And tell us about a bit about your background firstly, and what are you doing here in Australia? Well, certainly. Well, I've been a very avid skier myself for most of my life. In fact, I've spent about 25 years in the ski industry.

And so it's certainly a pleasure to be here in Australia. I'm taking part in the Australian Snow Expo shows and meeting with the various travel trade partners and agents that do such a great job of selling our destinations. So excited to be here and such a great opportunity to chat with you today.

Yes, it's wonderful to have you on the program. And I've actually been to British Columbia. I was actually in Alberta for the Winter Olympics back in 1988.

It's a long time ago, but I had such a wonderful time in that part of the world. I didn't get a chance to visit Fernie at that point. I would be very much looking forward to a visit soon.

Can you tell us a bit about this resort? It's a fantastic resort in BC. Well, certainly. Well, I've been a resident there myself for over 20 years.

So it certainly has grown on me. Fernie, it's a very special part of British Columbia. We're located in the southeast corner of the BC Rockies.

So we do sit within that stunning Canadian Rockies landscape and mountains and scenery. It's really a well-known destination from that snow and ski experience. Fernie is known for its deep legendary powder.

And that's something that has been a long time claim of fame. We get up to 11 meters of snow, if you can believe. Wow, that's a lot.

Averaging about nine meters. But still, when you start to think about how deep that is, it's a lot of snow that we shovel over the course of every season. Great thing about Australia is we've had early snowfall.

So it looks like our season is going to be tremendous this year in 2026. So that's a good thing too. Now, you're on the Lizard Range near the town of Fernie.

And Fernie Alpine Resort is really easy to get to the town, isn't it? You've got a whole infrastructure there. I mean, we are a small mountain town. We're a population of just over 6,000 people.

And getting to Fernie is easier than you think. People are arriving into Canada. Generally, they're coming through Vancouver.

And we are just a one-hour flight from Vancouver into the Cranbrook area, Canadian Rockies International Airport. From there, it's just a one-hour drive, the actual town of Fernie itself. And so Fernie, it sits approximately seven kilometers from the base of Fernie Alpine Resort.

And you're right, Fernie Alpine Resort sits amongst the stunning Lizard Range. It's a succession of five big alpine bowls that make up the resort. We do have a local shuttle that operates between the town and the resort so it can help move people, whether they're staying up on the mountain to come down into town for dinner and activities, or for those guests choosing to stay right in our community, then lifts them up to the mountain on a daily basis.

So there are options for shuttles. If people don't feel like driving our Canadian roads, we understand that. And people can certainly also get to us from the Calgary area, which you mentioned.

Calgary is a three-hour drive away from Fernie. And it is, though, the major international gateway airport. So yeah, there's an option as to which way you arrive into our destination and lots of options once you get here.

And I know that a lot of Australians are really into powder skiing, and you guys certainly have that on offer. You've got 10 lifts servicing 142 named runs. That's an incredible amount of choice for powder freaks.

Well, it is. And in fact, we're now at 145 named runs, but always more, always more out there. And certainly, you know, the powder experience is something that many people are, you know, they look for, they dream of as a ski and snowboard enthusiast.

But I do want to ensure that people know that, you know, if you're not feeling incredibly competent at skiing powder, we do definitely have groomed runs. There is groomed terrain. We have an excellent winter sports school that can certainly provide anybody with the lessons that they need.

And also a great fleet of equipment for those wider skis to give people even better opportunity to really enjoy the powder. Now, at my age, when I was a younger man, I was a bit of a crazy skier. But these days, I love those really long, wide family runs.

I suppose you have a bunch of those too, where people can just really relax and enjoy the

scenery. Yeah, absolutely. And I think that's the beauty of what Fernie offers as a ski destination in that there is an incredible variety of terrain.

As I mentioned, it's a very sizable ski area. It's over 2,500 acres. We have over a thousand meters of vertical.

The dispersion of the runs, we do have, you know, a very good lower mountain area, well-suited for beginners and those that are kind of getting their legs under them. There is 32% of the mountain that is blue or intermediate terrain. Then certainly for those that like the steeps and the deeps, well, there is ample terrain that is off of all the different ridge lines.

The Alpine Bowls, they really do provide that little bit more open sense of cruising, as you've mentioned. And as noted, there is opportunities for people to ride the lift together and still find the right type of terrain for them each to meet down at the bottom and head up again. So, well-dispersed throughout the whole mountain.

Also, Fernie is part of a couple of other resorts, Kimberley and Kicking Horse Resorts too. Are they nearby to you or people can get to those easy? Yeah, absolutely. And you know, Fernie, so it sits on an area that's known as the Powder Highway.

The Powder Highway runs through the Kootenay region. And so, there are a number of different resorts and cat ski operations and high ski operations that are situated along this Powder Highway. So, Fernie is firmly situated on there.

The resort of Kimberley, Alpine Resort, is just over an hour, about an hour and 20 minutes away from Fernie. And you can continue on north up the valley and you can get to Kicking Horse Mountain Resort, which is just under three hours away. So, there's great options for individuals that are also looking for a multi-center type destination.

Certainly, you can have your fill and ski at Fernie for days on end. I am certainly someone who can attest to that. I've skied for years and still terrain that I'm exploring.

It does give people that opportunity to come out and experience a little bit more of what the Canadian skiing, you know, is out there. We should mention that one of the most important things for many skiers out there is the apres ski. And tell us a bit about Fernie's apres ski scene.

Certainly. I mean, who doesn't like apres? It's certainly the apres part. I think that's why we go skiing, isn't it? Sure.

Yeah. From three o'clock onwards, it's a whole different world. You know, and Fernie, definitely, as I mentioned, it's got a very, very community-minded, laid-back, fun energy and atmosphere to it.

The Gris Bar is certainly one of the beloved spots up on the mountain. It has a great retro feel to

it. Mounds of nachos and whatnot.

And you get into the community of Fernie itself. And that's where we're really fortunate to have an array of live music. We have a craft brewery, craft stillery that's in town.

So lots of options depending on what people are looking for to still find energy in the evening to go out and enjoy. I suppose you get a lot of Aussies coming by too, because Australia and Canada, we've got a big exchange program for staff and all that sort of thing. But I suppose when Aussies get there, they really get into the spirit of things.

Well, we do celebrate Australian Day in Canada and definitely at the resort as well. We are very fortunate to welcome a number of our staff in the community that come from Australia. They're probably our greatest word of mouth.

There's many people who have come on holidays because someone told them they had such a great time when they were spending their season. And so we do have a variety of international individuals that come and work in the destination. And so happy to have our Australian play a role in that too.

Christine Grimbale, how can people find out more about Fernie and the other resorts too that are under your umbrella? Yeah, absolutely. So online, one of your greatest resources will be heading to tourismfernie.com. There's a wealth of information that's on there with respect to accommodation, to dining, to activities, how to get to our destination, and certainly speaks to the resort experience itself. For those looking for a little bit more information about Fernie Alpine Resort, they can also then go directly to skiferntie.com, and that takes you to the resort's website.

And looking at some of the resorts that I mentioned, Kimberley, Kicking Horse, that's part of Resorts of the Canadian Rockies, and that's accessible through skircr.com. Excellent. And thank you very, very much for coming to Australia and being with us in the community, in the ski community. And I suppose you've met some fascinating people at the ski shows while you've been here.

Honestly, I love being here. I love connecting. I love the passion for everybody that's so excited and so committed to getting out and enjoying the ski experience.

I find that when I connect with people, they're talking about how Fernie is on their bucket list, Canada's on their bucket list. And I think that's really something that we're fortunate in our part of the world, that we have just this abundance of incredible scenery, amazing mountains and ski destinations to choose from, a really friendly, welcoming environment. And so, yeah, I've met a lot of people.

I really enjoy it. And I often have actually connected with people year over year. So I chatted with some fellows last year, and they ran into me at the Melbourne show and told me they booked

Fernie because of our conversation.

So hopefully I'll see them on the chairlift. Christine Grumble from Tourism Fernie, thanks so much for being part of Travel Radio Australia this month. It's been my pleasure.

Thank you so much for having me on your show.